

Djokovic comes back as Sabalenka starts strongly in Beijing

From: BBC Tennis Mined: 2026-10-03 3 min read

Novak Djokovic had to work hard to keep his winning run going in Beijing. The six-time **champion** beat China's Bu Yunchaokete 4-6 7-6 (7-2) 6-2 to reach the third round of the China Open.

Bu won the first set. Djokovic then needed a medical timeout and spoke to a trainer while trying to regain his breath between points. He played strongly in the second-set **tie-break**. In tennis, a **tie-break** is a short contest used to decide a set when the players are level in games.

In the final set, Djokovic won four games in a row. A backhand winner ended the match after two hours and 52 minutes. The 39-year-old has never lost in Beijing across 31 matches.

Aryna Sabalenka also began her tournament with a win. She beat Mexico's Renata Zarazua 6-1 6-3 in 63 minutes. She hit 11 **aces**. In tennis, an ace is a serve that lands legally without the other player touching it.

Sabalenka lost her world number one **ranking** and US Open title to Elena Rybakina in September. She said expecting more from herself can drive her forward, but can also **drain** her energy.

Now ranked second, she is trying to be easier on herself. Her next **opponent** is Nikola Bartunkova, a 20-year-old Czech player who came close to beating her in June.

Word Treasure

champion -- Someone who has won a competition.

tie-break -- A short tennis contest that decides a set when players are level in games.

aces -- Legal serves that the other player does not touch.

ranking -- A player's position in an ordered list of players.

opponent -- The person a player competes against.

drain -- To use up or reduce something, such as energy.

Background you need

In tennis, a tie-break helps decide a set when the players are level in games.
An ace is a legal serve that the receiving player does not touch.

Break it down

Introduces Djokovic's win and the round he reached.
Explains his comeback, medical timeout and match finish.
Reports Sabalenka's opening win and explains aces.
Ends with Sabalenka's thoughts about self-pressure and her next opponent.

Why it matters

The matches show two players advancing at the China Open. Sabalenka also describes how high expectations can motivate her while using up her energy.

Test what you remember

1. Who did Djokovic beat to reach the third round?
 - (A) Renata Zarazua
 - (B) Bu Yunchaokete
 - (C) Elena Rybakina
 - (D) Nikola Bartunkova
2. What happened in the first set of Djokovic's match?
 - (A) Djokovic won the set.
 - (B) The set ended in a tie.
 - (C) The set was cancelled.
 - (D) Bu won the set.
3. How many games in a row did Djokovic win in the final set?
 - (A) Five games
 - (B) Two games
 - (C) Three games
 - (D) Four games
4. How long did Sabalenka's match last?
 - (A) 52 minutes
 - (B) 63 minutes
 - (C) 31 minutes
 - (D) 39 minutes
5. What is an ace in tennis?
 - (A) A serve that lands outside the playing area
 - (B) A point replayed after a pause in the match
 - (C) A legal serve the other player cannot touch
 - (D) A shot that touches the net and goes back
6. What did Sabalenka say about expecting more from herself?
 - (A) It means she avoids difficult matches.
 - (B) It makes her stop caring about results.
 - (C) It can motivate her or drain her energy.
 - (D) It always helps her save energy.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: D 4: B 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Aryna Sabalenka: She said expecting more from herself can drive her forward or drain her energy, and she is trying to be easier on herself.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):